

TINAMOUS

The ground-dwelling tinamous from Central and South America resemble Old World partridges, but they are most closely related to ratites.

Tinamous, the sole family in the order Tinamiformes, are small, ground-dwelling birds with a rounded body and short legs. All have a very short tail, which gives them a dumpy appearance, and some species are crested.

Unlike the ratites, tinamous have a ridged breastbone for the attachment of flight muscles, a feature that is seen in all other birds. Their wings are much better developed than those of the ratites, and they can fly, although only over short distances. Usually they are reluctant to take to the air and prefer instead to run away from predators. Tinamous have a comparatively small heart and lungs, which perhaps explains why these birds become exhausted so easily.

Some groups of tinamous inhabit woodlands and forest, while others are found in open grassland. All feed on seeds, fruit, insects, and sometimes small vertebrates. The cryptic plumage patterns of most species makes them difficult to spot in the wild. They are more likely to be recognized by their distinctive call.

BEAUTIFUL EGGS

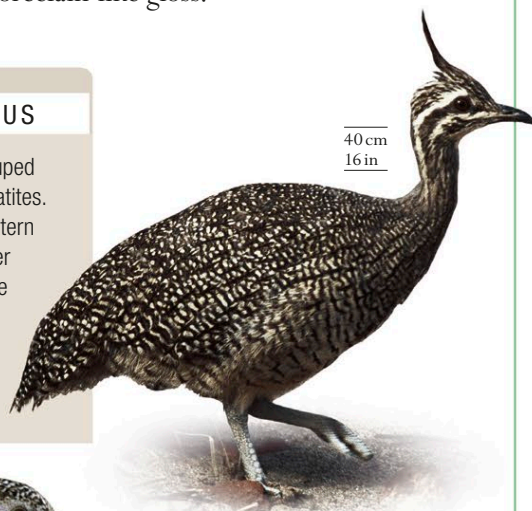
Male tinamous mate with many different females, and it is the males that tend the eggs and young. The nests are made in leaf litter on the ground. Tinamou eggs – brightly coloured turquoise, red, or purple – have a porcelain-like gloss.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	TINAMIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	47

DEBATE

ORIGINS OF TINAMOUS

Traditionally, tinamous are grouped separately from the flightless ratites. But the two groups share a pattern of skull bones not found in other birds, suggesting that they have a common ancestor. Scientists are not certain whether this ancestor was flightless or able to fly; the latter is more likely.



ELEGANT CRESTED TINAMOU

Eudromia elegans
F: Tinamidae

This bird of high-altitude shrubland occurs from S. Chile to Argentina. Unlike other tinamou species, it often lives in flocks.



ORNATE TINAMOU

Nothoprocta ornata
F: Tinamidae

An Andean tinamou, this species is found on the high montane grasslands of western S. America from Peru to N. Argentina.

RATITES

A group that includes the largest living birds, the ratites are flightless and strong footed. Some flock in open habitats; others live alone in forests.

Ratites evolved in the southern hemisphere and there is evidence to suggest they have flying ancestors. They lack some of the features associated with flight, but retain others.

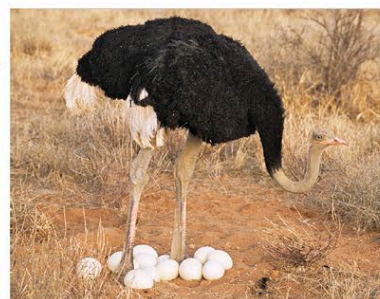
Ratites do not have the bony ridge on their breastbone that anchors powerful flight muscles in other birds, but they still have wings, and the part of the brain that controls flight is well developed.

The ostriches, which make up the order Struthioniformes, are found in dry open areas in Africa. They are powerful-limbed birds that can run at high speed on flat ground. Somewhat similar in appearance, though less massively built, are the rheas – the order Rheiformes – from the grasslands of South America. Like most ratites, both these groups of birds have a reduced number of toes: the rhea has three toes, the ostrich only two. Both have large wings that they use in displays or to assist their balance when sprinting.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDERS	4
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	13

AUSTRALASIAN SPECIES

The Australasian ratites include the cassowaries and emus of the order Casuariiformes and the kiwis, the Apterygiformes. All are forest birds, save the emu, which inhabits scrubland and grassland. The tiny wings of these ratites are invisible under their plumage, which resembles shaggy hair rather than feathers. The nocturnal kiwis, familiar as the national symbol of New Zealand, are the only ratites that do not have a reduced number of toes.



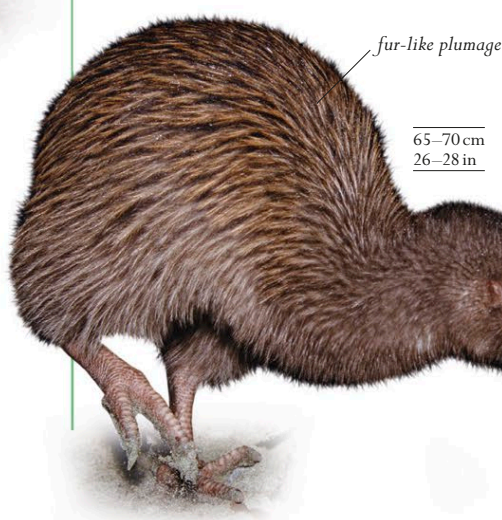
The male ostrich scrapes out a shallow nest in the ground, in which his harem of females lay up to 50 eggs.



NORTH ISLAND KIWI

Apteryx mantelli
F: Apterygidae

One of several New Zealand kiwis, this nocturnal ratite detects buried invertebrate prey by smell, using nostrils at its probing bill tip.



TOKOEKA

Apteryx australis
F: Apterygidae

This is the South Island cousin of *A. mantelli*. Lighter coloured than its relative, it has been recognized as a separate species after DNA analysis.